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net sessions. The boys had to trust each other before they could fight for each other.

So, we invested heavily in team-building. I remember our first tour to South India for the KSCA Invitational tournament. We realised quickly that long trips were opportunities, not just logistical necessities.

During dinner sessions, we assigned quirky tasks. One player had to wear his T-shirt inside out. Another had to wear his cap the wrong way. A few were told to turn up in dark glasses at night. It sounds harmless, but those small acts broke down invisible walls. The boys laughed at one another, cracked jokes and began to see teammates as individuals rather than representatives of regions.

On the field, we introduced non-cricket games before warm-ups. It relaxed them and encouraged communication. Slowly, the dressing-room atmosphere changed — it became more organic and more collective.

Travel, however, remained a stark reminder of systemic neglect. Earlier, players travelling from Jammu and Kashmir to the southern parts of India often endured exhausting journeys. In many cases, they had overnight layovers and spent the night at airports before catching connecting flights. For young cricketers trying to make a mark, that sends the wrong message.

We told the administration clearly that if there was an overnight halt, the players must be accommodated in a hotel. It was about dignity.

During Vijay Hazare Trophy matches in Chennai, I remember telling the administration that even if there was a layover, the boys had to be put up in a hotel. Arrangements were made immediately, and the team stayed in a five-star property in Aerocity. To some, it may have seemed a small administrative tweak. But for the boys, it meant everything. It told them they were valued. It gave them physical rest and emotional reassurance. Thankfully, the administrators understood our

reasoning and supported us.

The real challenge surfaced in the first selection meeting I attended in 2018. The discussion was divided neatly into two segments: Jammu and Kashmir. There were effectively two camps in the room. Selectors from Jammu pushed for Jammu players. Selectors from Kashmir pushed for Kashmiri players.

That was not healthy. Talent does not carry a regional stamp.

That selection was declared null and void. It conveyed our intent. We said clearly: we do not care if the playing XI is entirely from Jammu or entirely from Kashmir if that is what merit dictates. Selection would be based purely on performance and potential.

There was resistance. Mindsets do not change overnight. But we persisted because we believed that without a broader vision, the team would not progress.

Gradually, the resistance softened. Players sensed the shift. They realised that if they performed, they would get a fair chance. That transparency built